

DistroForge

User Guide · 0.9 Beta

Build your own Debian-based Linux distribution as a live ISO, step by step.

DistroForge
0.9 Beta · ISO builder for Debian-based distributions

1. Start

Quick Wizard

2. Repositories

3. Identity & Branding

4. Users

5. Language

6. Desktop

7. Software

8. Kernel & Boot

9. Look & Feel

10. Installer

11. Advanced

12. Review & Apply

13. Check & Build

Settings & About

Support DistroForge

Send feedback

Dark mode

My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 8 of 13 · Kernel & Boot — 13 done

Kernel Boot Loader Boot Menu

Boot Loader

Step 8 · The boot loader the installer puts on computers. Install the ones you want into the image, remove the others, choose one and set it up. Every choice works with the Calamares installer; when a boot loader cannot work on a computer, the next one that can is used.

Boot loaders

Select a boot loader to read about it and to change its settings below.

Boot loader	Computers	In the image	Installer
GRUB 2	BIOS and UEFI	—	✓ used by the installer
GRUB 2 with Secure Boot	BIOS and UEFI (Secure Boot on)	—	
systemd-boot	UEFI	—	
rEFInd	UEFI	—	
EFISTUB	UEFI (Secure Boot off)	—	
Syslinux / EXTlinux	BIOS	—	
LILO	—	not available	

EFISTUB (UEFI (Secure Boot off)) — No boot loader at all: the UEFI firmware starts the Linux kernel directly, the fastest start. Kernel updates are copied to the EFI partition by themselves. Secure Boot must be off. BIOS computers get Syslinux (if installed) or GRUB.

Install into the image

Remove from the image

Use for installed systems

Back: 7. Software

done Done — next step: 9. Look & Feel

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux
List Flatpak apps
List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

Hide log

Hugo Moniz do Rego · GPL-3.0-or-later · <https://github.com/hugomonizdorego/Eduka-Customizer>

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1. What is DistroForge?

DistroForge is free and open source software (GPL-3.0-or-later) to build your own Linux distribution from Debian or a Debian derivative. The result is a live ISO that boots from a USB stick or DVD (BIOS and UEFI) and installs with the Calamares installer.

You can start from:

- a live ISO of Debian or a Debian derivative (for example LMDE, MX Linux, antiX, Kali Linux, Parrot OS, Deepin, SparkyLinux, BunsenLabs, Q4OS)
- a new Debian base system (stable, testing or sid) made with mmdebstrap/debootstrap
- a copy of this computer (snapshot)

Ubuntu-based ISOs (Ubuntu, Linux Mint's Ubuntu edition, Pop!_OS, elementary OS, Zorin OS) are not supported: DistroForge is made for Debian-based distributions. DistroForge itself installs on Debian, Debian derivatives and Ubuntu.

The work is split into 13 steps. The next step opens when the one before is done, so you always know what comes next. Experts can open every step in Settings.

- 1 Start · 2 Repositories · 3 Identity & Branding · 4 Users · 5 Language · 6 Desktop
- 7 Software · 8 Kernel & Boot · 9 Look & Feel · 10 Installer · 11 Advanced
- 12 Review & Apply · 13 Check & Build

2. Installing and starting

Install the .deb package (it pulls in every tool it needs):

```
sudo apt install ./distroforge_0.9.0~beta_all.deb
```

Start it from the application menu (**DistroForge**) or a terminal:

```
distroforge          # the window (asks for the admin password)
sudo distroforge --help # command line
```

The old command `eduka-customizer` still works and opens DistroForge. Old settings in `/etc/eduka-customizer` are read automatically.

Needs: Debian 12 or newer (or a derivative), 4 GB RAM, free disk space of three times the ISO size.

3. Step 1 · Start: create a project

Choose where your distribution comes from: open an ISO, download an official Debian live ISO, bootstrap a new Debian base, or copy this computer. Each project is one folder with the system, the settings and the built ISO, each in its own sub-folder (see 'The project folder').

Purpose asks what the distribution is for (home, office, school, gaming, server, ...) and the ISO edition (minimal, standard, full). Use or ignore its recommendations.

The screenshot shows the 'Start' screen of the DistroForge application. On the left is a dark sidebar with a list of steps from 1 to 13, with '1. Start' highlighted. Below the steps are buttons for 'Support DistroForge', 'Send feedback', and 'Dark mode'. The main area has a header with 'My Linux' and 'Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64'. The 'Start' section explains the goal: 'Step 1 - Create a project and choose where your distribution starts from: a Debian live ISO (the small 'standard' ISO is recommended), another Debian-based ISO, a new Debian base, or this computer.' There are two main sections: 'New project' and 'Open project'. 'New project' has input fields for 'Name' (with placeholder 'project name, e.g. My Linux') and 'Folder' (with placeholder '/home/eduka-customizer/my-distro'), a 'Browse...' button, and a 'Create project' button. 'Open project' has a text area with a file path and 'Open selected' and 'Browse...' buttons. Below these is the 'Source of the image' section, which asks to 'Choose where the root filesystem comes from. Replacing the source deletes the current root filesystem of this project.' It has a 'Default language:' dropdown set to 'Keep the language of the source' and a checkbox for 'Install translations (needs internet)'. At the bottom of this section are tabs: 'Debian / Debian-based ISO' (selected), 'Download Debian', 'New Debian base', and 'This computer'. A progress bar at the bottom shows 'Step 1 of 13 · Start — 13 done'. A 'Done — next step: 2. Repositories' button is visible. A log window at the bottom shows 'Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux', 'Check the image', and 'Check the image finished'. The status 'Ready' is shown at the bottom left, and a 'Hide log' button is at the bottom right.

Step 1: create or open a project

The **Quick Wizard** asks everything important on 8 pages and prepares it all at once.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux

Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Quick Wizard — 13 of 13 steps done

Review & Apply: 5 waiting

Quick Wizard

The fast way: answer a few questions on one page after the other, then press Finish. Every step can be fine-tuned afterwards.

Back

1. Source

2. Identity

3. Base system

4. Desktop

5. Look

6. Applications

7. Branding

8. Finish

Where does the system come from?

Project folder:

/home/distroforge/mylinux

Browse

Source:

Keep the system of the open project

ISO file:

Browse

Architecture (new base):

amd64

Open project: /home/distroforge/mylinux (Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64)

Recommended source: the Debian live **standard** ISO (no desktop, minimal). Any Debian live ISO or a Debian derivative such as LMDE works too.

What is your distribution for?

Fills the next steps with recommendations (desktop, login screen, look, applications). Change anything you like afterwards, or choose 'Other' to decide everything yourself.

Other / my own — No recommendations: build everything yourself, page by page.

ISO edition

Full with recommended apps — Full, plus the desktop's recommended applications and the Flatpak apps (largest ISO). Recommended.

✓ List Flatpak apps finished
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install 3 package(s)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Use boot loader EFISTUB
Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the system sound theme
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the welcome screen

Added to Review & Apply: Install the welcome screen (5 waiting)

Hide log

Quick Wizard

4. Steps 2 to 5 · Repositories, Identity, Users, Language

Repositories: the Debian version (stable, testing, sid), the mirror, contrib/non-free-firmware and other repositories.

Identity & Branding: name, version, code name, web site, logo and wallpaper. The values start from what the ISO has. DistroForge builds a branding package that replaces os-release, lsb-release, issue, logos, the GRUB menu and the installer branding. Use a name and logo of your own: names such as 'Debian ...' or 'Ubuntu ...' are trademarks, and the check warns about them.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 3 of 13 · Identity & Branding — 13 done

Identity Distro Branding

Distro Branding

Step 3 · Your name, logo, colors and artwork everywhere: system information, login, GRUB, boot splash and installer. DistroForge packs them into a <id>-branding package, so Debian updates keep them. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 12).

1. Identity and artwork

Your branding. Load from the ISO starts again from the extracted ISO.

Load from the ISO

Name: My Linux

ID (lower case): mylinux

Version: 1.0

Codename: Aurora

Home page: https://example.org

Support URL:

Bug report URL:

Maintainer: My Linux developers <mylinux@localhost>

Logo:

Back: 2. Repositories Done — next step: 4. Users

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

Ready Hide log

Support DistroForge
Send feedback
Dark mode

Identity & Branding

Users: the live user (default live, full name Live), with or without a password, automatic login and more accounts. **Language:** default language, keyboard, time zone (default Asia/Dili) and language packs, also for the installer and the boot menu.

5. Steps 6 and 7 · Desktop and Software

Choose a desktop (GNOME, KDE Plasma, Xfce, Cinnamon, MATE, LXQt, Budgie, ...) or a window manager and its edition under the names the desktop itself uses. Set the login screen and default session too.

The screenshot shows the DistroForge 0.9 Beta ISO builder interface. The sidebar on the left lists steps 1 through 13, with '6. Desktop' highlighted. The main area is titled 'Desktop' and shows 'Step 6 of 13 - Desktop - 13 done'. Below the title, it says 'Step 6 · Choose a desktop environment or window manager and how complete it is (Mini, Compact, Full, Full with apps), then the login screen, X11 or Wayland and the compositor. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 12)'. The main content area is titled 'Desktop environment or window manager' and displays a grid of 16 options:

Eduka-Desktop ✓ Desktop	GNOME Desktop	KDE Plasma Desktop	Xfce Desktop
Cinnamon Desktop	MATE Desktop	LXQt ✓ Desktop	LXDE Desktop
Budgie Desktop	GNOME Flashback Desktop	Enlightenment Desktop	Openbox ✓ Window manager
i3 Window manager	Fluxbox Window manager	IceWM Window manager	awesome Window manager
JWM Window manager	herbstluftwm Window manager	bspwm Window manager	dwm Window manager
spectrwm Window manager	Sway (Wayland) Window manager	labwc (Wayland) Window manager	Wayfire (Wayland) Window manager
Hyprland (Wayland)			

At the bottom of the grid, there are navigation buttons: 'Back: 5. Language' and 'Done — next step: 7. Software'. The bottom status bar shows 'Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux', 'Ready', and a 'Hide log' button.

Desktops and editions

Software: search, install and remove Debian packages; add Flathub applications by category; and replace the default applications (browser, mail, editor, terminal, ...) for all users.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux

Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 7 of 13 · Software — 13 done

Packages

Fatpak apps

Replace apps

Packages and Applications

Step 7 - Every Debian package of the image: search, tick to add, untick to remove. You can also remove the applications that came with the ISO. Your changes wait in Review & Apply (step 12).

Maintenance

Refresh package lists

Upgrade all

Autoremove

Install .deb files...

Synaptic / terminal / live desktop...

All Debian packages

Ticked = installed in the ISO. Green: installed or to be installed; red: to be removed. 'Applications' hides libraries and other parts nobody starts from the menu.

office

Applications

All sections

Package	Version	Section	Size (KiB)	Description
☐ hyphen-as	0.9.0-2	text	21	Assamese hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-bn	0.9.0-2	text	21	Bengali hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-gu	0.9.0-2	text	21	Gujarati hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-hi	0.9.0-2	text	21	Hindi hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-kn	0.9.0-2	text	21	Kannada hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-ml	0.9.0-2	text	22	Malayalam hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice
☐ hyphen-mr	0.9.0-2	text	21	Marathi hyphenation patterns for LibreOffice

Back: 6. Desktop

done

Done — next step: 8. Kernel & Boot

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

Ready

Hide log

Packages

6. Step 8 · Kernel & Boot

Three tabs: **Kernel** (Debian, backports or third-party kernels, firmware, drivers), **Boot Loader** (what installed computers start with) and **Boot Menu** (the menu of the ISO itself).

Boot Loader. Install the boot loaders you want into the image, remove the others, choose the one the installer puts on computers (**Use for installed systems**) and set it up below:

- **GRUB 2** — BIOS and UEFI, menus, themes, other operating systems. Recommended. Settings: timeout, kernel options, menu style, default entry, os-prober, recovery entries, resolution.
- **GRUB 2 with Secure Boot** — the same, signed by Debian and started by shim.
- **systemd-boot** — small and fast, UEFI. Settings: timeout, kernel options, default entry, editor, screen mode.
- **rEFInd** — graphical, finds every system by itself, UEFI (Calamares 3.3). Settings: timeout, kernel options, resolution, text mode, tools row.
- **EFISTUB** — no boot loader: the UEFI firmware starts the kernel directly. Secure Boot must be off. Settings: kernel options, name in the firmware menu.
- **Syslinux / EXTlinux** — the small classic boot loader for BIOS computers (/boot on ext2/3/4, not encrypted). Settings: timeout, kernel options, menu title, graphical menu.

Every choice works with the Calamares installer. GRUB, systemd-boot and rEFInd are installed by Calamares itself; EFISTUB and Syslinux by an own installer step. When a boot loader cannot work on a computer (Syslinux on UEFI, EFISTUB on BIOS, an encrypted /boot) the next one that works is used, GRUB last, so the installation does not stop with an error. After kernel updates EFISTUB and Syslinux are kept up to date by themselves.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux

Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 8 of 13 - Kernel & Boot — 13 done

Kernel

Boot Loader

Boot Menu

Boot Loader

Step 8 - The boot loader the installer puts on computers. Install the ones you want into the image, remove the others, choose one and set it up. Every choice works with the Calamares installer; when a boot loader cannot work on a computer, the next one that can is used.

Boot loaders
Select a boot loader to read about it and to change its settings below.

Boot loader	Computers	In the image	Installer
GRUB 2	BIOS and UEFI	—	✓ used by the installer
GRUB 2 with Secure Boot	BIOS and UEFI (Secure Boot on)	—	
systemd-boot	UEFI	—	
rEFInd	UEFI	—	
EFISTUB	UEFI (Secure Boot off)	—	
Syslinux / EXTlinux	BIOS	—	
LILLO	—	not available	

EFISTUB (UEFI (Secure Boot off)) — No boot loader at all: the UEFI firmware starts the Linux kernel directly, the fastest start. Kernel updates are copied to the EFI partition by themselves. Secure Boot must be off. BIOS computers get Syslinux (if installed) or GRUB.

Install into the image

Remove from the image

Use for installed systems

Back: 7. Software

done Done — next step: 9. Look & Feel

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux

► List Flatpak apps

✓ List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

Hide log

Boot Loader

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux
Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 8 of 13 - Kernel & Boot — 13 done

Kernel
Boot Loader
Boot Menu

Syslinux / EXTlinux	BIOS	—	
LILO	—	not available	

EFISTUB (UEFI (Secure Boot off)) — No boot loader at all: the UEFI firmware starts the Linux kernel directly, the fastest start. Kernel updates are copied to the EFI partition by themselves. Secure Boot must be off. BIOS computers get Syslinux (if installed) or GRUB.

Install into the image
Remove from the image
Use for installed systems

Settings: EFISTUB

Kernel options: quiet splash

Name in the firmware boot menu (empty: the distribution name):

The kernel options are stored in the firmware's boot entry when the system is installed; root= is found by itself.

Defaults
Save settings

Check

What the installer will do with the chosen boot loader.

GRUB 2 is chosen but not installed in the image: press 'Use for installed systems' again Calamares is not installed yet in the image.

GRUB theme and the ISO's boot menu...
Check the installer...

Back: 7. Software
Done — next step: 9. Look & Feel

```

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux
List Flatpak apps
List Flatpak apps finished

```

List Flatpak apps — finished
Hide log

The settings of the selected boot loader

Boot Menu: title, timeout, kernel options and background of the ISO's menu, a third-party GRUB theme (checked first, refused when GRUB could not show it), the menu designer (rename, reorder, add or remove entries) and, for experts, the boot files themselves.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux
Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 8 of 13 - Kernel & Boot — 13 done

Kernel
Boot Loader
Boot Menu

GRUB theme

A theme folder or archive with theme.txt (for example from gnome-look.org or a theme's GitHub page). It is used by the GRUB menu of the ISO (UEFI) and, if you like, of installed systems. The BIOS menu of the ISO is ISOLINUX: it keeps its background (Boot Menu tab).

Drop a GRUB theme folder or archive (.zip, .tar.gz, .tar.xz) here

Add files...
Add folder...

Theme:
Also for installed systems (GRUB_THEME)
Remove theme
Use this theme

The ISO's own GRUB look is in use.

Menu designer

The entries of the ISO's GRUB menu: rename them (double-click), change the order, remove some or add ready-made ones; choose the default entry, the timeout and the colors. Saved like a manual edit, so every build keeps it.

Edukasaun OS Live (amd64)

Utilities

Back: 7. Software
Done — next step: 9. Look & Feel

```

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux
List Flatpak apps
List Flatpak apps finished

```

List Flatpak apps — finished
Hide log

GRUB theme and menu designer

7. Step 9 · Look & Feel

Five tabs: **Themes & Icons** (only what fits the chosen desktop), **Wallpaper & Login**, **Plymouth** (boot animation), **System Sounds** (start-up, login, log out, errors, notifications) and **Welcome Screen** (four pages shown after the first login).

The screenshot shows the 'Themes & Icons' configuration screen in the DistroForge installer. The left sidebar lists steps 1 through 13, with '9. Look & Feel' selected. The main area has tabs for 'Themes & Icons', 'Wallpaper & Login', 'Boot Splash', 'System Sounds', and 'Welcome Screen'. The 'Themes & Icons' tab is active, showing a section to 'Add your own themes, icons, cursors and fonts' with a dashed box for dropping files. Below this is a section for 'Install theme packs' with a list of available themes like Papyrus icons, Numix Circle icons, etc. At the bottom, there's a 'Back' button and a 'Done' button leading to step 10. A terminal window at the bottom shows the command 'List Flatpak apps' and its output.

Themes and icons

The screenshot shows the 'Welcome Screen' configuration screen in the DistroForge installer. The left sidebar is the same as the previous screenshot. The main area has the 'Welcome Screen' tab selected. It contains a 'Welcome screen' section with options to add a welcome screen, set a window title, logo, and show the screen at every login. There are also color pickers for background, text, titles, buttons, and button text. Below this is a 'Pages' section for designing the welcome screen pages. At the bottom, there's a 'Back' button and a 'Done' button leading to step 10. A terminal window at the bottom shows the command 'List Flatpak apps' and its output.

Welcome screen

8. Steps 10 and 11 · Installer and Advanced

Installer: the Calamares installer — modules, order, slides, default partitioning and texts. **Check the installer** finds mistakes before the build; the **How to fix** column says whether a problem is fixed automatically.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64 Step 10 of 13 · Installer — 13 done

Result	File	Details	How to fix
✗ Problem	/etc/calamares/settings.conf	settings.conf...	Automatic: Install calamares
✗ Problem	/etc/calamares/settings.conf	branding ...	By hand
✗ Problem	/etc/calamares/settings.conf	the 'sequenc...	By hand

3 problem(s), 0 warning(s)

[Fix automatically](#) [Check the installer](#)

Users and passwords

- ☐ Log in automatically (default of the checkbox)
- ☒ Ask for a root password
- ☒ Offer 'use the same password for root'
- ☐ Allow weak passwords
- ☐ 'Allow weak passwords' ticked by default

Password length: min max

User groups:

Administrator group:

Shell:

Live user

These are the rules for the accounts the installer creates. The user of the live session, its password (or no password) and accounts built into the image are set on the Users page.

Live user: **user** — Debian default password ('live')

[Users and passwords...](#)

Back: 9. Look & Feel done Done — next step: 11. Advanced

```
Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux
List Flatpak apps
List Flatpak apps finished
```

List Flatpak apps — finished [Hide log](#)

Installer check

Advanced: a terminal inside the image, the live session in a window (Xephyr), hook scripts, JSON recipes and the package workshop to change files of installed Debian packages.

9. Step 12 · Review & Apply

Changes from steps 2 to 11 **do not** change the image right away. They all wait in the Review & Apply list. The blue button at the top shows how many are waiting.

- Tick every change you are sure about.
- **Go back and change it** opens the step of that change.
- **Remove from the list** drops a change; **Up/Down** change the order.
- **Apply all changes** is enabled when everything is ticked. If one change fails, the ones applied before it leave the list and the rest keep waiting.

Experts can apply every change at once (Settings → Apply every change at once).

The screenshot shows the DistroForge ISO builder interface at Step 12: Review & Apply. The left sidebar contains a navigation menu with steps 1 through 13, with Step 12 highlighted. The main area displays the 'Review & Apply' screen for 'My Linux' (Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64). It lists five changes waiting to be applied, with the first two checked. Below the list are buttons for 'Tick all', 'Go back and change it', 'Remove from the list', 'Up', 'Down', and 'Apply all changes'. A status bar at the bottom shows '2 of 5 change(s) checked' and a 'Done' button. A log window at the bottom displays the progress of the changes.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64 Step 12 of 13 · Review & Apply — 13 done Review & Apply: 5 waiting

Review & Apply

Step 12 · Everything you chose waits here. Tick each change when you are sure, or go back and change it. Then apply them all at once.

Changes waiting to be applied

- ☒ 1. Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications) — Desktop
- ☒ 2. Install 3 package(s) — Software → Packages
- ☐ 3. Use boot loader EFISTUB — Kernel & Boot → Boot Loader
- ☐ 4. Apply the system sound theme — Look & Feel → System Sounds
- ☐ 5. Install the welcome screen — Look & Feel → Welcome Screen

2 of 5 change(s) checked — tick every change you are sure about to apply them

Tick all Go back and change it Remove from the list Up Down Apply all changes

Changes run in this order. A failed change stops the rest; nothing is lost.

Your distribution so far
Name: My Linux 1.0

Back: 11. Advanced ✓ done Done — next step: 13. Check & Build

✓ List Flatpak apps finished
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the Xfce desktop (full with applications)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install 3 package(s)
Waiting in Review & Apply: Use boot loader EFISTUB
Waiting in Review & Apply: Apply the system sound theme
Waiting in Review & Apply: Install the welcome screen

Added to Review & Apply: Install the welcome screen (5 waiting) Hide log

Support DistroForge Send feedback Dark mode

Review & Apply

10. Step 13 · Check & Build

Check now finds what would make the build fail, the ISO not boot, or private data leak into it. Every row says how to fix it:

- **Automatic:** ... — press **Fix automatically**; DistroForge fixes it and checks again.
- **By hand (double-click)** — double-click the row to open the right step.

When you press **Build ISO image** with problems left, DistroForge asks: **Fix automatically, I will fix it myself** or **Build anyway**.

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux

Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 13 of 13 · Check & Build — 13 done

Check & Build

Last step - Check the image, choose the ISO size, build the ISO (BIOS and UEFI, ready for USB sticks) and try it in a virtual machine.

Check before building

Finds what would make the build fail, the ISO not boot, or private data leak into it.

Result	Check	Details	How to fix
✗ Problem	Installer	/etc/calamares/settings.conf: settings.conf is there but the ...	Automatic: Install calamares
✗ Problem	Installer	/etc/calamares/settings.conf: branding 'debian' has no folder wit...	By hand (double-click)
✗ Problem	Installer	/etc/calamares/settings.conf: the 'sequence' is empty	By hand (double-click)
✓ OK	Distribution	Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64	
✓ OK	Build tools on this computer	mksquashfs and xorriso found	
✓ OK	Package database	every package is fully installed	
✓ OK	Kernel	6.12.43+deb13-amd64 with its initrd (2 kernels)	

3 problem(s), 2 warning(s) — fix the problems before building

Deep check (apt-get check)

Fix automatically

Check now

ISO size

Choose how big the ISO may be. Compression is lossless: every file comes back exactly as it was, so a smaller ISO is never a damaged ISO — it only takes longer to build.

Target size:

No limit (fastest build)

Estimate

Back: 12. Review & Apply

done

Opened project /home/distroforge/myLinux

► List Flatpak apps

✓ List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished

Hide log

Check & Build

11. ISO size

Choose a target size: as small as possible, 100 MB, 300 MB, 500 MB, 700 MB (CD), 1 GB, 2 GB, 4.4 GB (DVD) or no limit. **Estimate** compresses a sample of the system and computes the size of every method.

Squashfs compression is **lossless**: every file comes back exactly as it was. A smaller ISO is never a damaged ISO, it only takes longer to build (xz is smallest and slowest, lz4 fastest).

When the target is too small, DistroForge suggests safe size savers: documentation, manual pages, unused translations, APT lists and old kernels. License files always stay. Removing applications you do not need helps most.

DistroForge
0.9 Beta - ISO builder for Debian-based distributions

1. Start
Quick Wizard
2. Repositories
3. Identity & Branding
4. Users
5. Language
6. Desktop
7. Software
8. Kernel & Boot
9. Look & Feel
10. Installer
11. Advanced
13. Check & Build
Settings & About

My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Step 13 of 13 · Check & Build — 13 done

image

File name: (id)-(version)-(suite)-(arch)-(date).iso
→ mylinux-1.0-stable-amd64-20261008.iso

Volume label: MYLINUX_1.0

Compression: zstd - fast, good (recommended) Level: 15

Boot loader: Automatic

Initramfs: Rebuild when needed

- ☒ Secure Boot (signed shim + GRUB, when generating)
- ☒ Remove Debian-Installer entries (Calamares installs the customized system)
- ☐ Reuse existing filesystem.squashfs (only boot files changed)
- ☐ Also write SHA-512 and MD5 checksums

Clean-up before compressing
Keeps private data and caches out of the ISO.

- ☒ Clean APT package cache
- ☒ Empty log files
- ☒ Reset machine-id (regenerated on boot)
- ☒ Remove saved network connections
- ☐ Remove old kernels, keep the newest
- ☒ Remove Flatpak download caches
- ☐ Remove APT package lists (smaller ISO, run apt update after install)
- ☒ Remove shell history and root's caches
- ☒ Remove SSH host keys (regenerated on boot)
- ☒ Empty /tmp and /var/tmp
- ☒ Remove caches from /etc/skel
- ☐ Smaller ISO: remove documentation in /usr/share/doc (keeps license files)

Back: 12. Review & Apply done

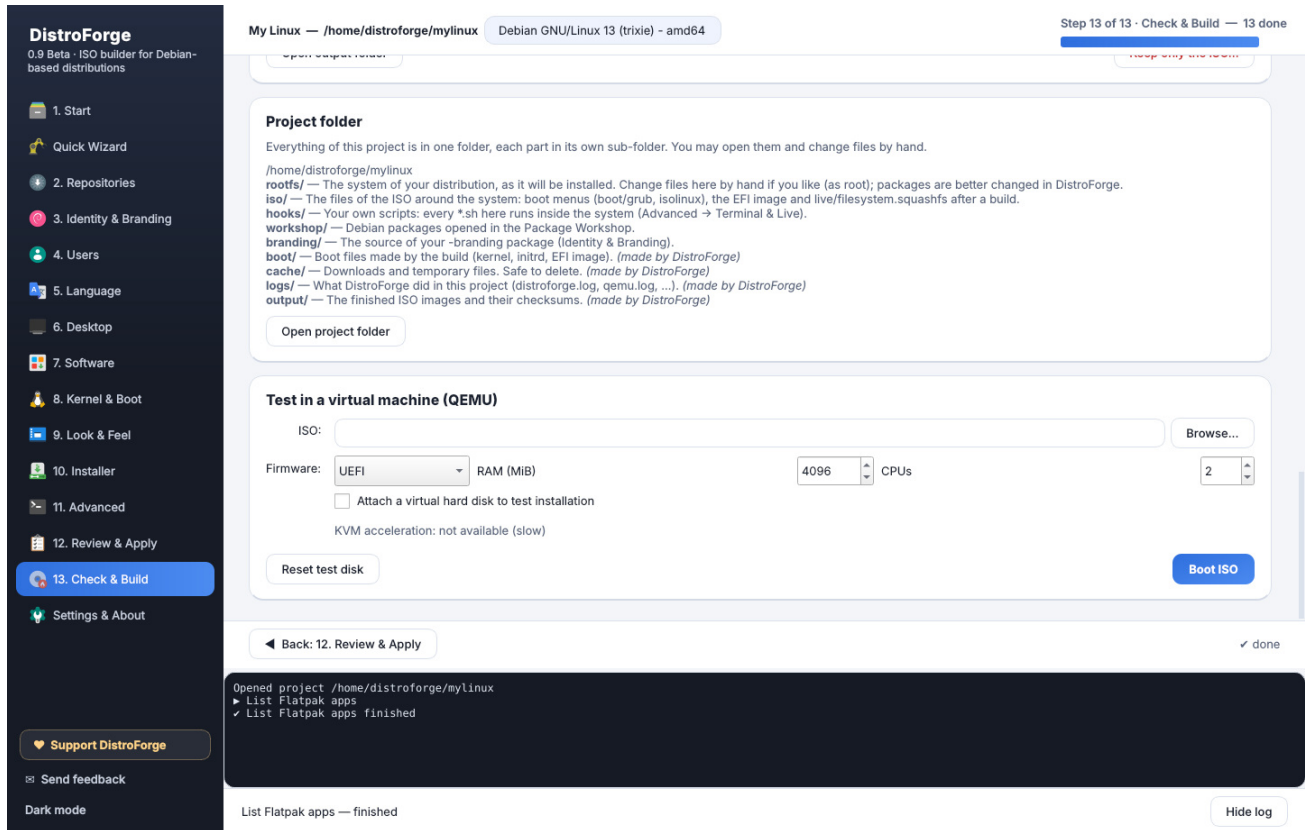
Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux
List Flatpak apps
List Flatpak apps finished

List Flatpak apps — finished Hide log

Target size and build options

12. The project folder and keeping only the ISO

Everything of a project is in one folder, each part in its own sub-folder, so you can also open them and change files by hand: `rootfs/` (the system), `iso/` (boot menus and the files around the system), `hooks/` (your scripts), `workshop/`, `branding/`, and `boot/`, `cache/`, `logs/`, `output/` made by DistroForge. `README.txt` in the folder explains them.



Result and project folder

The build folders are big. When the ISO is finished and tested, **Keep only the ISO...** (or closing the window after a build) deletes everything of the project but the ISO and its checksum files, which move into the project folder. Nothing is deleted while anything is still mounted inside the project, and files of your own in the folder stay. The command line does the same with `distroforge clean --keep-iso`.

13. Testing and writing to USB

After the build, **Boot ISO** in the **Test in a virtual machine** card boots the ISO with QEMU (BIOS, UEFI or UEFI with Secure Boot). The ISO is hybrid: write it to a USB stick with GNOME Disks, balenaEtcher, Ventoy or:

```
sudo dd if=mylinux.iso of=/dev/sdX bs=4M status=progress oflag=sync
```

Replace /dev/sdX with the right USB device; everything on it is erased.

14. Command line

Every step is also available in a terminal, in the order of the work. The commands apply each change at once (Review & Apply is only in the window).

```
sudo distroforge new --iso debian-live.iso ~/mylinux
cd ~/mylinux
sudo distroforge brand identity name="My Linux" version=1.0
sudo distroforge apt install vlc gimp
sudo distroforge boot-loader list
sudo distroforge boot-loader set systemd-boot TIMEOUT=3
sudo distroforge boot-loader use systemd-boot
sudo distroforge check --fix
sudo distroforge build --target-size 700
sudo distroforge test
sudo distroforge clean --keep-iso
```

`distroforge --help` lists the commands by step; `distroforge COMMAND --help` explains one command.

15. Common problems and feedback

- **'grub needs /usr/sbin/grub-install in the image'** — not reported for live ISOs that install GRUB from the ISO pool during installation. If it shows, press Fix automatically.
- **Half-installed packages** — Fix automatically runs `dpkg --configure -a` and `apt-get -f install`.
- **Not enough disk space** — remove caches with `sudo distroforge clean`, or keep only the ISO of finished projects.
- **No internet** — installing packages and Flatpaks needs internet; all other edits work offline.
- **Log** — every message is in the log panel and in `/tmp/distroforge/distroforge.log`.

Send feedback (in the sidebar, in Settings, and in every error message) sends a bug report, an error, an idea or a question to the developers, with screenshots or other files and, if you agree, the logs. Without internet the report is kept and sent the next time DistroForge starts.

Tell the developers

Report a bug or an error, suggest something, or ask a question. Add screenshots or other files if they help. The report is sent to the developers of DistroForge.

What is it? An idea or a recommendation

Title: A dark blue accent color

Message: It would be nice to choose the accent color of the window.

Your e-mail: Optional: your e-mail address, if you would like an answer

Drop screenshots, logs or other files here (8 MB together at most)

Add files...

logo.png (2 KB)

Add a screenshot of the main window

Remove the selected file

☐ Add the logs of DistroForge and the settings of the open project (recommended for bugs and errors)

Nothing else is collected. The report travels encrypted (HTTPS); without internet it is kept and sent the next time DistroForge starts.

Cancel Send

Send feedback

16. License, trademarks and support

DistroForge is free software under the GNU General Public License version 3 or later, WITHOUT ANY WARRANTY. The license of every component (Python, Qt, squashfs-tools, xorriso, GRUB, systemd-boot, rEFInd, Syslinux, Calamares, live-boot, Papius, ...) is listed on the **About** tab of Settings & About. The packages in your ISO each keep their own license (/usr/share/doc/PACKAGE/copyright).

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My Linux — /home/distroforge/mylinux Debian GNU/Linux 13 (trixie) - amd64

Settings & About — 13 of 13 steps done

Settings About

About

DistroForge 0.9 Beta — build your own Debian-based Linux distribution as a live ISO.

DistroForge
0.9 Beta
Free and open source software, licensed under the GNU General Public License version 3 or later (GPL-3.0-or-later).
Made by Hugo Moniz do Rego and contributors. DistroForge was called Eduka-Customizer until version 0.17 Alpha.
Project page: <https://github.com/hugomonizdorego/Eduka-Customizer>

Donate with PayPal Follow on Facebook Project page User guide (PDF)

DistroForge is free. If it helps you, a donation keeps the work going: <https://paypal.me/hugocenturion0311>

License

You may use, study, share and change DistroForge under the terms of the GNU GPL version 3 or later. It comes with ABSOLUTELY NO WARRANTY.

Show the license (GPL-3.0)

Credits

DistroForge by Hugo Moniz do Rego.
DistroForge is a rewrite of Customizer by Ivailo Monev, Mubini Kimura, Graham Cantin and contributors (GPL-2.0-or-later). Ideas are taken from Cubic (GPL-3.0), remastersys (GPL-3.0) and penguins-eggs (MIT); no code of these projects is copied. Menu icons from the Papius icon theme (GPL-3.0).

Opened project /home/distroforge/mylinux
► List Flatpak apps
✓ List Flatpak apps finished

Support DistroForge Send feedback Dark mode

List Flatpak apps — finished Hide log

About

Made by Hugo Moniz do Rego. If DistroForge helps you, a donation keeps the project going:

- PayPal: <https://paypal.me/hugocenturion0311>
- Facebook: <https://facebook.com/hugomonizdorego>
- Project: <https://github.com/hugomonizdorego/Eduka-Customizer>